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WAM

DATE HARVEST SHOWCASES UAE'S FARMING HERITAGE

■ An Emirati farmer carefully hand-picks ripe date clusters during the UAE's annual harvest season, which peaks in July and August. Harvested at the ideal stage of ripeness, the dates are sorted and graded before reaching local markets and export destinations. The seasonal harvest is celebrated across the country through festivals in Liwa, Al Ain, Al Wathba, Ajman, Al Dhaid and Dubai, highlighting the UAE's enduring date-farming heritage.

Wynn Al Marjan Island in RAK to open in September 2027

Construction cost rises by \$600m to approximately \$5.7b

DUBAI

BY DHANUSHA GOKULAN
Chief Reporter

Wynn Resorts has set September 2027 as the official opening date for Wynn Al Marjan Island, giving the UAE's first integrated resort a firm launch timeline as construction continues on one of the country's largest tourism developments.

The US-based hospitality group announced the opening schedule during its second-quarter earnings update, while also revealing that the

project's estimated construction cost has increased by \$600 million to approximately \$5.7 billion.

Wynn said it invested a further \$48.1 million in the development during the second quarter, taking its total cash contribution to \$1.06 billion. The company holds a 40 per cent stake in the joint venture developing the resort with Marjan and RAK Hospitality Holding.

Range of leisure attractions

Once completed, Wynn Al Marjan Island will feature more than 1,500 hotel rooms, suites and villas, alongside restaurants, entertainment venues, meeting and convention facilities, luxury retail, well-

ness amenities and a range of leisure attractions. The resort is also expected to become the UAE's first integrated resort with a regulated commercial gaming facility, subject to licensing by the General Commercial Gaming Regulatory Authority (GCGRA).

Located on Al Marjan Island in Ras Al Khaimah, the project is expected to strengthen the emirate's position as a luxury tourism destination and is widely regarded as one of the Middle East's most significant hospitality developments. The September 2027 opening will mark Wynn Resorts' first venture in the Middle East and one of the company's largest international investments.

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HORMUZ ROUTE AGREED WITH OMAN, SAYS IRAN

New attacks at sea cast doubt over hopes of quick breakthrough

DUBAI

BY STEPHEN N. R.
Senior Associate Editor

Iran said yesterday it had agreed with Oman on a new shipping route through the Strait of Hormuz and was putting the finishing touches to a joint framework for managing vessel movements, although it warned the vital waterway would remain unsafe as long as US military pressure continued.

Foreign Ministry spokesman Esmail Baqaei said the two sides had agreed on the geographical coordinates of the proposed route and were in the final stages of drafting a joint statement outlining the main points of agreement.

"The geographical coordinates of the route envisaged by the two sides have been agreed upon and, if certain third parties do not obstruct the process, the joint statement of the two countries, containing the main considerations and points of agreement, is also in the final review and drafting stage," Baqaei said, according to state news agency IRNA.

The announcement came a day after US President Donald Trump said a breakthrough could come "tomorrow or the next day", claiming "a lot of progress" had been made in efforts to reopen one of the world's busiest energy

corridors. But he also warned the US would strike Iran "really hard" if negotiations collapsed.

No direct US-Iran talks

Despite the apparent progress, Tehran insisted it was negotiating only with Oman and not directly with Washington. Baqaei also cautioned that any agreement would not immediately make Hormuz safe for international shipping.

"The factors making the Strait of Hormuz insecure still exist on the part of the United States, particularly the naval blockade and other aggressive and threatening actions against Iran and its interests," he said.

Security concerns remain high. A commercial vessel was damaged after being struck by an unidentified projectile while transiting the Strait of Hormuz this week, while an Indian-flagged cargo ship sank in the Red Sea after an attack blamed by Yemeni authorities on Iran-backed Houthi militants.

Before the conflict erupted in February, the Strait of Hormuz carried about a fifth of the world's traded oil and liquefied natural gas, making any agreement to restore safe navigation crucial for global energy markets.

— with inputs from AFP

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Qasr Al Watan among world's top 100 sites

Palace one of UAE's leading attractions

ABU DHABI

Qasr Al Watan has been recognised in both Trip.Best's Top 100 Global Attractions & Experiences 2026 and Top 100 Attractions & Experiences in Asia 2026, published by Trip.com.

Based on visitor reviews and performance indicators, the rankings highlight the palace's position as one of the UAE's leading cultural and heritage attractions.

Among the palace's highlights are the Great Hall, known for its traditional Arabian architecture and one of the world's largest central domes, and the Spirit of Collaboration chamber, where meetings of the Federal Supreme Council, the Arab League and the

Gulf Cooperation Council are held. The hall features an ornate chandelier made from 350,000 crystal pieces.

Visitors can also explore the Presidential Gifts exhibition, featuring gifts received by UAE leaders from foreign delegates during state visits, and the Presidential Banquet hall with a collection of over 100,000 delicate serve-

ware pieces.

The Qasr Al Watan Library houses more than 50,000 works documenting the region's literary and scholarly heritage.

The palace also hosts the Military Music Show every Monday, Wednesday and Friday at 2:30pm, and presents the daily Palace in Motion light and sound show at 7:30pm, which highlights the UAE's history, present and future.

— WAM



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